10

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The history of journalism is the history of leaks. Only in fiction is it the case that everything that happens is witnessed, in some sense, by the author. In journalism, the witness is often absent, and we rely on reports of the truth that use witness statements as part of the picture. In many cases, good journalism will rely on an absent witness, who, either on or off the record, will leak what they know. We forget that everyday journalism relies on the leak to an extraordinary degree. ‘According to documents seen by the *Washington Post*.’ ‘According to an unnamed senior official speaking yesterday.’ ‘Sources close to the subject say.’ ‘Information received by the *Daily Telegraph* suggests.’ The truth does not always come as a single spy, but it often comes inadvertently, or covertly, or via a blind source, and this has always been the case. We gather what we see, but also we gather what has been seen by people beyond the range of our own eyes.

With a trusted colleague, Rop Gonggrijp – founder of one of the first ISPs in the Netherlands and organiser of a long-running hacking conference in Amsterdam – I took up an invitation to attend the Hack in the Box Conference in Malaysia in October 2009. A lot of those gathered there were politically-minded and had been involved in the local reform movement. The government of Mahathir, leader of the Barisan Nasional, had been subject to strong opposition and calls for reform, spearheaded by Anwar Ibrahim of the People’s Justice Party. Ibrahim had previously, as finance minister, steered Malaysia out of financial crisis and was named ‘Asian of the Year’ by *Newsweek* in 1998. But by the time we arrived in Kuala Lumpur, things had long since changed for Ibrahim. After criticising the prime minister, he had served six years in prison for ‘corruption’ and was constantly smeared with sex allegations. When he got out of prison, he spent time advising the World Bank and served as a professor at St Anthony’s College, Oxford, and at Johns Hopkins, among other institutions,